“Everett-Wheeler interpretation.” Wheeler hastily replied, pointing out that “Everett’s PhD thesis was on a topic entirely conceived by him and ought to be called the Everett Interpretation, not the Everett Wheeler Interpretation.” Ever the scientific diplomat, Wheeler had tried to maintain his commitment to the ideas of Bohr, his late mentor, without explicitly denouncing the ideas of Everett, his former student. This wasn’t a difficult position for him to hold while Everett’s work languished in obscurity and remained cloaked in the language of the “relative-state formulation.” But now DeWitt was calling Everett’s view the “many-worlds” interpretation and saying that Wheeler was partly responsible for it—and the fact that it was showing up in science-fiction magazines didn’t help either. So Wheeler publicly distanced himself from Everett’s work and DeWitt’s spin on it. “[Everett’s] infinitely many unobservable worlds make a heavy load of metaphysical baggage,” Wheeler wrote in 1979. Though Wheeler had always strongly supported Everett’s physics career—and was still interested in Everett returning to academia after his twenty years in industry—he claimed that he had never supported Everett’s ideas. “Wheeler told me that he was always implacably opposed to the theory—what he supported was Everett,” said David Deutsch, who was a young researcher at Austin when Everett came to speak there. Shortly thereafter, Wheeler started promoting his own ideas about an information-based interpretation of quantum physics, ideas that he saw as compatible with the Copenhagen interpretation.

But Deutsch and many of the younger attendees at Everett’s seminar in Austin were enthusiastic about the many-worlds interpretation. Deutsch sat next to Everett at lunch in a beer garden after the talk. Everett was “full of nervous energy, high-strung, extremely smart, very much in tune with the issues of the interpretation of quantum mechanics,” Deutsch recalled. “He was extremely enthusiastic about many universes, and very robust as well as subtle in its defense, and he did not speak in terms of ‘relative states’ or any other euphemism.” Several years later, in his seminal paper on quantum computing, Deutsch claimed that only the many-worlds interpretation could explain the fabulous increase in speed that quantum computers offered. “The Everett interpretation explains well how the [quantum] computer’s behaviour follows from its having delegated subtasks to copies of itself in other universes,” Deutsch wrote. “When the [quantum] computer succeeds in performing two processor-days of computation, how would the